

The Center for Active Living (CAL)

Comprehensive Municipal, Environmental, and Legislative Investigation • Town of Hingham, MA

Subject Project: Center for Active Living (CAL / HCAL)	Location: Bare Cove Park Drive (Map 69, Lot 44)	Date: September 2026
Sponsoring Entity: Town of Hingham Select Board & CALBC	Warrant Target: 2026 ATM Article 12 (\$29.93M Debt)	Status: Defeated at Town Meeting (510–470)

25,950 SF
PROPOSED FACILITY AREA

\$29.93M
TOTAL BOND AUTHORIZATION

510 – 470
FLOOR VOTE (52.0% YES)

66.7% Req.
M.G.L. C. 44 DEBT HURDLE
(FAILED)

1. Executive Summary & Legislative Outcome

For over fifteen years, the Town of Hingham pursued a comprehensive solution to an acute municipal infrastructure deficit: replacing its undersized, 5,200-square-foot Council on Aging senior center, housed since 1997 in the windowless basement of Hingham Town Hall (210 Central Street). The culmination of this planning process was the proposed construction of a 25,950-square-foot **Center for Active Living (CAL)** on 5.387 acres of municipal land off **Bare Cove Park Drive** (Assessor Map 69, Parcel 44; 0 Fort Hill Street), accompanied by 140 parking stalls and brownfield remediation of a World War II naval munitions depot bunker.

Town Meeting Vote Failure (April 27, 2026): Under 2026 Annual Town Meeting Warrant **Article 12**, the Select Board requested authorization to borrow \$29,930,000 via a Proposition 2½ debt exclusion. Following two hours of intense floor debate, the standing counted vote was **510 In Favor (52.0%) vs. 470 Opposed (48.0%)**. While achieving a simple majority, the article **FAILED** because Massachusetts General Laws (M.G.L. c. 44, § 7) requires a **two-thirds (2/3) supermajority (66.67%)** for bonded municipal debt obligations. The measure fell 144 votes short of passage.

Demarcation from 100 Beal Street Senior Affordable Housing: A central point of civic confusion during 2025–2026 was the conflation of CAL with 100 Beal Street. They are completely separate projects: CAL was a *municipal civic community center* sponsored by the Town of Hingham on Bare Cove Park Drive; 100 Beal Street is an *affordable residential rental apartment complex (68 units)* sponsored independently by the **Hingham Housing Authority (HHA)** and developer **Peabody Properties** on School Tract II off Beal Street. CAL was never part of a "land swap" with 100 Beal Street, and its defeat had no legal invalidation on HHA's independent residential development.

2. Demographic Imperative & Project Origins (1997–2023)

Hingham's existing senior center was established in 1997 in a 5,200 sq. ft. basement footprint in Town Hall. As the town grew, the space became wholly inadequate. Demographic assessments conducted by the **UMass Boston Gerontology Institute** (*Aging in Hingham*, 2013 and 2022) revealed critical structural realities:

- **Demographic Expansion:** In 2025, Hingham recorded 7,904 residents aged 60+, representing **32% of the town's population**. By 2035, this cohort is projected to reach 9,000 residents or **39% of the population**—the highest proportion of seniors among all South Shore peer towns.
- **Chronic Health Needs:** The May 2025 *Healthy Aging in Massachusetts* report showed Hingham seniors (65+) exceed the state average for multiple chronic conditions, demanding localized health and physical therapy infrastructure.
- **Service Deficit:** 34% of Hingham seniors live alone and 30% serve as caregivers. Crucially, **32% of surveyed seniors reported traveling to other towns' senior centers** (such as Marshfield's 24,000 sq. ft. center) because Hingham's basement facility lacked adequate programming, fitness space, and parking.

3. Site Selection & Comparative Feasibility Analysis

Between 2021 and 2026, the Center for Active Living Building Committee (CALBC) held 67 public meetings alongside **EDM Studio, Inc.** (architects), **SLR International Corporation** (civil/environmental engineers), and **Lifespan Design Studio**. Siting options evaluated included:

Site Evaluated	Engineering & Municipal Findings	Final Siting Determination
Town Hall Expansion (4 Variations Assessed)	Evaluated renovating the vacated Police Department wing. Building layout was structurally constricted and could not provide adequate programmatic square footage. Severe parking deficit would require paving over Cronin or Haley athletic fields , sparking fierce youth sports opposition.	Rejected as Infeasible Space reassigned to SSRECC dispatch expansion.
South Shore Country Club (Union Street Driving Range)	High traffic congestion at Hingham High School campus; complex topography; environmental and golf course master plan conflicts.	Rejected Severe traffic bottlenecks.
Hitchcock Shoes Site (225 Beal Street)	Private commercial parcel under active purchase-and-sale agreement; acquisition cost uncertainties and structural limitations.	Rejected Private commercial site unavailable.
100 Beal Street (School Tract II)	Owned in fee simple by HHA; dedicated under M.G.L. c. 121B, § 34 state deed restriction for senior affordable residential housing.	Excluded Committed to HHA residential procurement.
Bare Cove Park Drive (Map 69, Parcel 44)	5.387-acre municipal site. Sufficient upland for single-story 25,950 SF footprint, 140 parking stalls, and opportunity to remediate blighted WWII naval ammunition depot bunker.	RECOMMENDED SITE Approved by CALBC & Select Board.

4. Architectural Design, Environmental Review, & Article 97

Building Architecture: 25,950 sq. ft. single-story, ADA-compliant, all-electric facility designed under Massachusetts Specialized Energy Code standards. Program features commercial kitchen for Meals on Wheels, clinical health rooms, SHINE Medicare counseling suites, fitness center, art studios, and senior van dispatch hub.

Article 97 Compliance: Siting on parkland required compliance with Article 97 of the Massachusetts Constitution. Hingham Town Meeting authorized an Article 97 petition (2025 ATM Art. 16) transferring 5.387 acres off Bare Cove Park Drive, while dedicating **7.0 acres of municipal land off High Street near Plymouth River School** as permanent conservation replacement land. The Secretary of EOEEA issued an approval letter on October 3, 2025, and the Massachusetts Legislature enacted the act into law on February 6, 2026.

Conservation & Wetlands Permitting: Horsley Witten Group completed a peer review on February 3, 2026 for the Hingham Conservation Commission, evaluating SLR's Request for Determination of Applicability. Delineated resource areas included Bordering Vegetated Wetland (Wetland A), Isolated Vegetated Wetland (Wetland B), Potential Vernal Pool (PVP #10722), and a perennial stream draining to the **Weymouth Back River ACEC**.

5. Financial Architecture & Tax Impact Modeling

The January 2026 capital budget codified in Article 12 totaled **\$29,927,423** (\$29.93M):

- **Direct Building Construction:** \$19,964,549 (66.7%)
- **Site Development, Utilities, Demolition & Remediation:** \$6,213,950 (20.8%)
- **Soft Costs, Furnishings, Testing & Contingency:** \$4,348,924 (14.5%)
- **Ancillary Infrastructure (Funded via DPW / Grants):** \$400k water main extension, \$275k road repaving, and \$300k Fort Hill St traffic signal.

Assessed Home Valuation	FY27	FY28	FY29 (Peak Impact)	FY30	FY31
\$750,000	\$30	\$60	\$155	\$152	\$149
\$1,075,000 (Median Valuation)	\$43	\$86	\$222	\$218	\$214
\$1,367,000 (Average Valuation)	\$55	\$109	\$283	\$277	\$272
\$2,000,000	\$80	\$160	\$414	\$406	\$398

6. The Floor Debate & Town Meeting Defeat (April 27, 2026)

At the April 27, 2026 Annual Town Meeting, Article 12 was debated for over two hours in the Hingham High School gymnasium:

- **Proponents (Select Board 3–0, Advisory Committee 9–5):** Argued that seniors had waited thirty years in an undignified basement; that 39% of the town would soon be seniors; that delay would dramatically escalate construction inflation; and that the project eliminated a blighted munitions bunker.
- **Opponents (Bare Cove Park Preservationists & Abutters):** Argued that Bare Cove Park is irreplaceable public open space; that clearing five acres of woodland severed wildlife corridors; that traffic at Fort Hill Street was unmanageable; and that the cumulative impact of three projects (CAL, 100 Beal St housing, and pickleball courts) threatened "death by a thousand cuts" to **Tucker's Swamp, Hockley Run, and the Weymouth Back River ACEC**.
- **The Floor Vote:** The standing counted vote recorded **510 YES (52.0%) to 470 NO (48.0%)**. Because M.G.L. c. 44, § 7 mandates a **two-thirds (66.67%) supermajority for debt authorization** (requiring 654 votes out of 980 cast), Moderator Michael Puzo declared the article **DEFEATED**.

7. Comparative Analysis: CAL vs. 100 Beal Street Senior Affordable Housing

Dimension	Center for Active Living (CAL)	100 Beal Street Senior Affordable Housing
Core Mission & Use	Municipal Civic Center: Daytime recreation, health clinics, congregate nutrition, classes, and senior socialization.	Residential Housing: Permanent affordable rental apartments (68 units) for low- and moderate-income elders.
Sponsoring Body	Town of Hingham: Select Board, Council on Aging, and Center for Active Living Building Committee (CALBC).	Hingham Housing Authority (HHA): Independent public body corporate and politic under M.G.L. c. 121B.
Statutory Framework	M.G.L. c. 44, § 7 (Bond Debt); Mass. Const. Art. 97 (Parkland).	M.G.L. c. 121B, § 34; M.G.L. c. 40B, §§ 20–23 (Zoning Relief).
Parcel Location	Bare Cove Park Drive (Map 69, Parcel 44; 0 Fort Hill St).	100 Beal Street (Map 58, Lot 23; School Tract II).
Acreage & Program	5.387 acres: 25,950 SF single-story building; 140 parking stalls.	8.6-acre Lot B disposition: 68 residential units in 3-story building.
Capital Funding	\$29.93M municipal borrowing funded via local property taxes.	Private capital, Federal LIHTC equity, MassHousing, and state bonds.
Town Meeting Role	Required 2/3 legislative vote to borrow debt (Failed 510–470).	Town Meeting vote not required; HHA holds statutory disposition authority.
Current Status	DEFEATED AT TOWN MEETING (Siting search reset).	ACTIVE (Peabody Properties; ORAD issued; 40B pending).